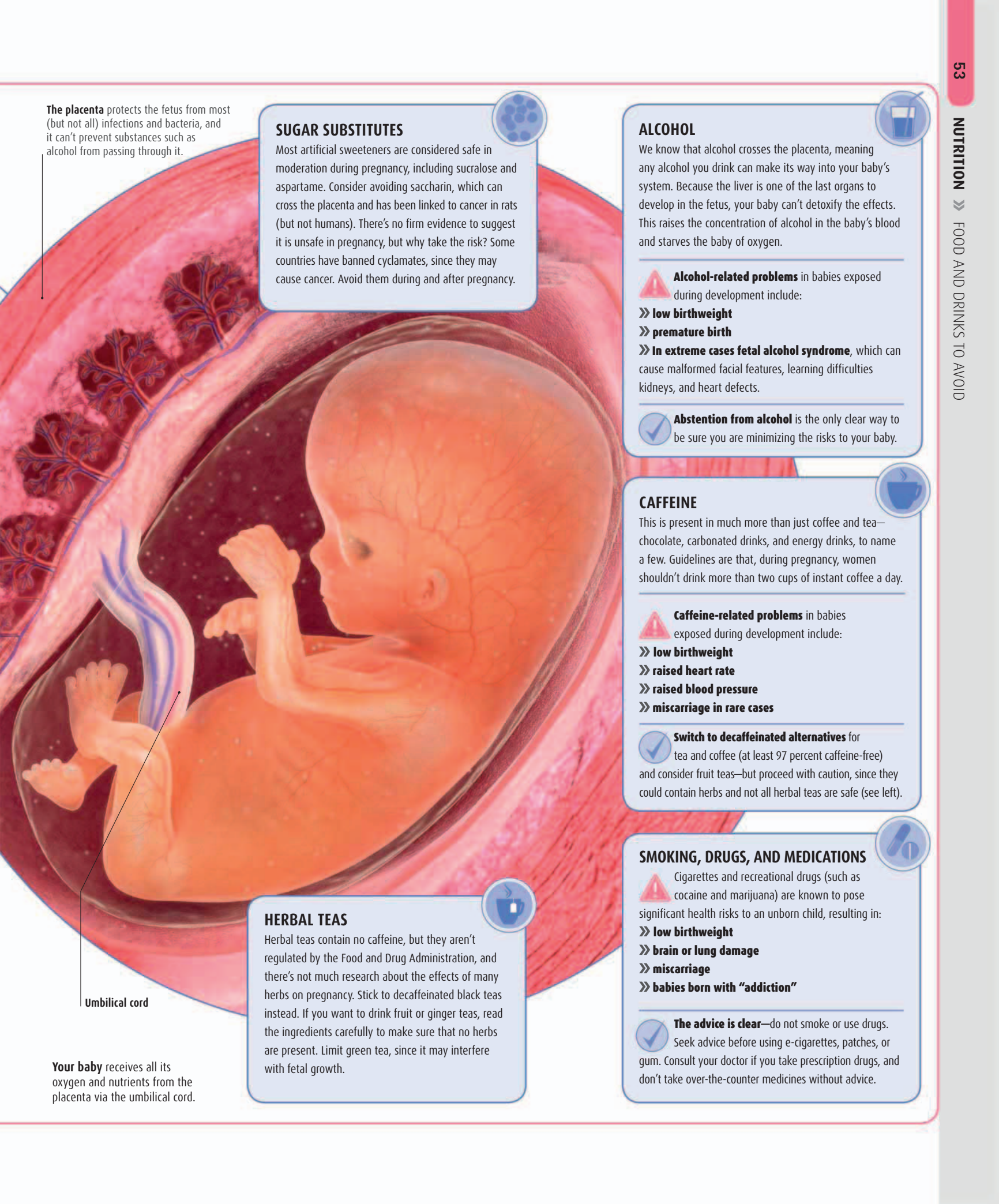




The **placenta** protects the fetus from most (but not all) infections and bacteria, and it can't prevent substances such as alcohol from passing through it.

SUGAR SUBSTITUTES

Most artificial sweeteners are considered safe in moderation during pregnancy, including sucralose and aspartame. Consider avoiding saccharin, which can cross the placenta and has been linked to cancer in rats (but not humans). There's no firm evidence to suggest it is unsafe in pregnancy, but why take the risk? Some countries have banned cyclamates, since they may cause cancer. Avoid them during and after pregnancy.

ALCOHOL

We know that alcohol crosses the placenta, meaning any alcohol you drink can make its way into your baby's system. Because the liver is one of the last organs to develop in the fetus, your baby can't detoxify the effects. This raises the concentration of alcohol in the baby's blood and starves the baby of oxygen.

Alcohol-related problems in babies exposed during development include:

- » **low birthweight**
- » **premature birth**
- » **In extreme cases fetal alcohol syndrome**, which can cause malformed facial features, learning difficulties, kidneys, and heart defects.

Abstinence from alcohol is the only clear way to be sure you are minimizing the risks to your baby.

CAFFEINE

This is present in much more than just coffee and tea—chocolate, carbonated drinks, and energy drinks, to name a few. Guidelines are that, during pregnancy, women shouldn't drink more than two cups of instant coffee a day.

Caffeine-related problems in babies exposed during development include:

- » **low birthweight**
- » **raised heart rate**
- » **raised blood pressure**
- » **miscarriage in rare cases**

Switch to decaffeinated alternatives for tea and coffee (at least 97 percent caffeine-free) and consider fruit teas—but proceed with caution, since they could contain herbs and not all herbal teas are safe (see left).

SMOKING, DRUGS, AND MEDICATIONS

Cigarettes and recreational drugs (such as cocaine and marijuana) are known to pose significant health risks to an unborn child, resulting in:

- » **low birthweight**
- » **brain or lung damage**
- » **miscarriage**
- » **babies born with "addiction"**

The advice is clear—do not smoke or use drugs. Seek advice before using e-cigarettes, patches, or gum. Consult your doctor if you take prescription drugs, and don't take over-the-counter medicines without advice.

HERBAL TEAS

Herbal teas contain no caffeine, but they aren't regulated by the Food and Drug Administration, and there's not much research about the effects of many herbs on pregnancy. Stick to decaffeinated black teas instead. If you want to drink fruit or ginger teas, read the ingredients carefully to make sure that no herbs are present. Limit green tea, since it may interfere with fetal growth.

Umbilical cord

Your baby receives all its oxygen and nutrients from the placenta via the umbilical cord.